I asked him about the serious charges he was facing. *'Sab saazish hai, bahut badi saazish hai'* (It is all a big conspiracy). I asked him who was behind the conspiracy. *'Poora Congress isme involved hai. Yeh chahte hain ki Modiji ko target karein aur mujhe isme phasaye'* (The whole Congress is involved. They want to target Modi and trap me), he said firmly. I sensed that adversity had brought Shah and Modi closer together. It was almost as if Shah was taking the bullets as a proxy for his 'saheb'. It was a 'sacrifice' that meant Modi was almost beholden to his junior minister. In an interview I did with Modi in 2012, I had asked him a question on Shah's legal travails. It was the one question he asked me to later edit out.

So, was Shah really the 'most dangerous man in Gujarat', as one police officer once described him to me? Was he, as one of the arrested police officers, D.G. Vanzara, claimed in a letter, an 'evil influence' on Modi? (Shah claims the letter was dictated by the Congress.) Or was he, as his supporters insisted, 'One of the most honest and straightforward persons you could wish to meet, an ace political mind'? The verdict was evenly split, depending on who you spoke to.

A former *Tehelka* journalist, Rana Ayyub, who had carried out a detailed investigation on Shah's alleged role in encounter killings, claims that the minister's men once tried to browbeat her. The magazine was pulled out of the news stands in Gujarat, and Ayyub got threatening calls. When nothing seemed to work, she received a courier package at her hotel in Ahmedabad with a wad of notes. 'I fear someone was trying to bribe me into getting off the story,' she says.

A local Gujarat journalist describes Shah as a karyakarta first, a political leader later. Apparently, when a local UP businessman offered to finance the BJP campaign, Shah did not entertain him for more than a few minutes. 'You must meet my district head first,' he told him. But when an RSS worker came to his office, he spent half an hour with him, trying to understand what was happening on the ground. 'He is the strong, silent type who likes his work to do the talking, he is not a *hawabaaz* [gasbag],' is how an old friend describes him.